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THEATRE ARTS

DRAMATIC CRITICISM

How to Review a Play

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The working method of a theatre review: what to watch, what to write down, how to judge, and how to say what a production did rather than what you would have done.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- preparation
- note-taking
- judgement
- structure
- ethics

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Before the curtain

Read the play before you go, if a text exists. Know what the production has chosen to do with it, so that you can tell the difference between a mistake and an interpretation. Arrive early enough to see the auditorium, the programme and the audience; the audience is part of the event.

What to watch

Watch four things at once and write in the interval. First, the action: what does each character want, and does the production make it visible? Second, the acting: are the actors listening, or waiting to speak? Third, the staging: space, levels, movement, design, light - does the production have a visual argument? Fourth, the audience: where does it lean forward, where does it cough?

Write down specific moments, not adjectives. "The second act began with the table still uncleared and the two women circling it" is evidence; "the direction was dull" is a verdict without a case.

Judgement

A review judges a production against its own aims, then against the play's, then against the standard of the art. Say what the production tried to do, whether it did it, and whether it was worth doing. That last question is the critic's real work and the one student reviewers avoid.

Be fair to difficulty: a company with no budget that attempts a hard play is doing something different from a funded company that attempts an easy one. Say which you are reviewing.

Writing and ethics

Lead with the production, not with the plot. Quote one line of dialogue, describe one stage picture, name the actor who did the thing that mattered. Keep the review to the space you are given; eight hundred words is a discipline, not a limit.

Review the work, not the people's private lives. Do not invent facts about the budget or the rehearsal. If you did not see the whole performance, say so. A critic who is trusted is a critic who can be checked.

The review as an argument

A review is an argument with evidence, not a verdict with adjectives. The claim might be "this production turns a domestic tragedy into a ghost story", and the evidence is three specific choices: the lighting, the doubling, the way the maid is directed to stand. A reader who did not see the show should be able to follow the argument and disagree with it.

Structure it simply. Open with the production's central choice; describe two or three moments that show it working or failing; place it in the context of the company and the play; end with a judgement that follows from the evidence. The plot summary belongs in one sentence, and only if the reader needs it.

Avoid the three common failures: reviewing the play instead of the production, reviewing your own expectations, and reviewing the audience. You are writing about what happened on a particular night in a particular room, and the specificity is what makes it criticism rather than a notice.

The paragraph that does the work

Almost every good review has one paragraph that carries the argument: a description of a moment, followed by what it meant, followed by why it mattered. Write that paragraph first, then build the review around it. If you cannot write it, you do not yet have a review; you have notes.

Keep your notebook open in the interval and write the moment down before you talk to anyone. The opinions of the person beside you are the fastest way to lose your own.

Exercises

1. Review a production in 400 words, with at least three specific moments as evidence.
2. Rewrite a review that consists of adjectives into one that consists of observations.
3. Write two reviews of the same show, one for a student paper and one for a national newspaper, and compare the assumptions.

Where to read more

Clayton Meeker Hamilton, The Theory of the Theatre (1910)

George Jean Nathan, The Critic and the Drama (1922)

Eric Bentley, The Playwright as Thinker (1946)

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